

Preservation and Revitalisation of Nigerian Indigenous Languages Through Digital Media in South-West Nigeria

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Abstract

This study explores how digital media contributes to the preservation and revitalisation of indigenous languages in South-West, Nigeria. The theories considered relevant to the study are Jenkins's theory of Digital Participation and Cultural Capital Theory and Fishman's theory of Reversing Language Shift (RLS). The theories are relevant because they account for the methods for reviving endangered languages and explain how online engagement promotes cultural empowerment. A descriptive survey was adopted, combining quantitative and qualitative data to examine attitudes and practices related to digital media and language use. Thirty (30) purposively sampled participants from Lagos, Oyo, and Osun states were selected from youths and content creators engaged in digital platforms (e.g., YouTube, TikTok, WhatsApp), through semi-structured interviews (qualitative-thematic analysis). The paper investigates patterns of language use, motivations, and perceived impacts of digital media on Yoruba, Ìjèṣà, and Ìgbómìnà languages. Results show that digital media has significantly enhanced language visibility, intergenerational communication, and creative usage, though challenges such as digital literacy and platform bias remain.

Keywords: Indigenous languages, digital media, language preservation, South-West Nigeria, revitalisation

Introduction

Language preservation is critical to cultural identity (Fishman, 1991). Digital media can act as a revitalisation tool by providing platforms for minority languages (Cunliffe et al., 2013). In African contexts, digital platforms have been used to document endangered languages, teach scripts, and support community interaction (Mafuka & Mufwene, 2020). Across the globe, indigenous languages are increasingly threatened by globalisation, urbanisation, and the dominance of international languages such as English (UNESCO, 2023). In multilingual societies such as Nigeria, indigenous languages play a crucial role in sustaining cultural heritage and facilitating social cohesion. However, many Nigerian indigenous languages are increasingly threatened by globalisation, urbanisation, formal education policies, and the dominance of English as the official language. In South-West Nigeria, although Yoruba remains one of the most widely spoken indigenous languages in Africa, concerns persist about

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declining proficiency, reduced intergenerational transmission, and diminishing use of dialectal varieties such as Ìjèṣà, Ìgbómìnà, and Èkìtì, particularly among younger speakers.

Traditionally, indigenous language transmission in South-West Nigeria occurred through oral practices such as storytelling, proverbs, songs, rituals, and communal interactions. With socio-economic changes, migration, and the increasing preference for English in formal and semi-formal domains, these traditional modes of transmission have weakened. As a result, indigenous languages face not only reduced functional domains but also negative attitudinal perceptions, where they are often viewed as unsuitable for modern communication, education, and technology. According to Statista (2024), more than 122 million Nigerians use the internet, mainly through mobile phones, which has transformed patterns of communication, education, and cultural consumption.

In recent years, digital media has emerged as a transformative force reshaping communication practices globally. Social media platforms, instant messaging applications, video-sharing sites, and digital audio tools have created new spaces for language use, documentation, and dissemination. In Nigeria, platforms such as WhatsApp, YouTube, TikTok, Facebook, and Instagram have become integral to everyday communication, entertainment, and learning. These platforms offer unprecedented opportunities for indigenous language preservation by enabling users to create, share, and archive linguistic content without institutional gatekeeping. For example, the Masoyinbo digital game show in Nigeria embodies this potential by leveraging interactive digital content to engage both local and diaspora users in Yoruba language activities, thereby enhancing language retention through audience participation and gratification frameworks. This illustrates that digitally mediated interactions can have both cultural and educational benefits, echoing uses and gratifications theory — where users seek content that fulfils cultural and identity needs.

Beyond preservation, digital media also holds potential for language revitalisation, particularly among youths who dominate online spaces. Through creative digital practices such as comedy skits, short videos, podcasts, memes, and captioned posts, indigenous languages are being recontextualised in contemporary and appealing forms. This process not only increases language visibility but also challenges the perception of indigenous languages as obsolete or irrelevant.

Despite these opportunities, the effectiveness of digital media for indigenous language sustainability remains under-examined empirically, especially at localised regional levels. Existing studies often adopt broad national or theoretical perspectives, with limited attention to how users in specific regions engage with digital platforms for language purposes. Moreover, there is a need for qualitative insight into how speakers themselves perceive digital media as tools for preservation and revitalisation. Against this backdrop, this study empirically investigates the preservation and revitalisation of Nigerian indigenous languages through digital media in South-West Nigeria, using content analysis of data obtained from 30 participants. By focusing on actual user experiences and digital practices, the study contributes to ongoing discussions on language sustainability in the digital age.

Literature Review

The preservation of indigenous languages has emerged as a central topic in sociolinguistics, communication studies, and digital humanities. Nigeria's linguistic landscape is both diverse and endangered. Scholars such as Bamgbose (2019) and Adegbiya (2020) have emphasised that colonial language policies and the entrenchment of English as the official language created

long-term linguistic hierarchies. Indigenous languages have been systematically marginalised in education, governance, and urban communication. Language endangerment occurs when a language loses speakers, functional domains, and intergenerational transmission. Scholars argue that language loss entails the erosion of cultural knowledge, worldview, and identity embedded in linguistic structures. In Africa, colonial legacies, post-colonial language policies, and globalisation have intensified language shift toward European languages, particularly English and French. In Nigeria, the preference for English in education, governance, and socio-economic mobility has marginalised indigenous languages. Although Yoruba enjoys numerical strength, scholars caution that numerical dominance does not automatically guarantee vitality, especially when younger generations increasingly prefer English or Nigerian Pidgin in digital and urban contexts. Dialectal varieties within Yoruba are even more vulnerable, as standard forms often overshadow them.

Language preservation refers to efforts aimed at documenting, maintaining, and protecting a language from extinction, often through recording, archiving, and formal description. Revitalisation, on the other hand, involves active measures to restore language use in daily communication, especially among younger or previously disengaged speakers. Fishman's theory of Reversing Language Shift emphasises intergenerational transmission and community involvement as critical to language survival. More recent perspectives argue that revitalisation must also account for contemporary communicative domains, including digital environments. This shift has led to growing interest in how technology mediates language practices and reshapes linguistic ecologies. Digital media has redefined language documentation by making recording tools accessible to non-experts. Audio recordings, videos, and text posts allow speakers to document oral traditions, narratives, songs, and everyday speech. Unlike traditional archives, digital platforms enable immediate circulation and community participation.

Studies on minority and indigenous languages across different contexts show that digital media serves as a living archive where languages are not only stored but actively used. In African contexts, mobile phones and social media have been identified as particularly effective due to their affordability and widespread adoption. In South-West Nigeria, WhatsApp voice notes and YouTube videos have been widely used to share sermons, folktales, cultural teachings, and informal conversations in Yoruba. These practices contribute to language preservation by extending usage beyond physical communities into virtual spaces.

Beyond preservation, digital media plays a revitalising role by reshaping how languages are perceived and used. Youth-driven platforms such as TikTok and Instagram enable playful, creative, and informal language use, which is crucial for revitalisation. Humour, music, and storytelling in indigenous languages attract engagement and encourage imitation. Research indicates that when indigenous languages appear in popular digital genres, they gain symbolic capital and social relevance. This process counters language stigma and fosters positive language attitudes. In Nigeria, digital skits and memes in Yoruba have become popular, demonstrating that indigenous languages can thrive in modern, entertainment-driven contexts.

Language is a powerful marker of identity. Digital media provides spaces where speakers publicly assert linguistic and cultural identities. Online use of indigenous languages often reflects resistance to linguistic homogenisation and a desire to affirm ethnic belonging. For speakers in South-West Nigeria, using Yoruba online functions as both communication and identity performance. Digital language practices reinforce group solidarity and cultural pride, especially among diasporic and urban populations who may be physically distant from traditional communities.

Despite its potential, digital media presents challenges for indigenous language sustainability. Algorithmic bias often favours dominant global languages, limiting the visibility of indigenous language content. Additionally, digital literacy gaps, internet costs, and limited institutional support constrain participation, particularly among older speakers. Scholars also note that without deliberate planning, digital language use may remain fragmented and informal, lacking long-term sustainability. These challenges highlight the need for empirical, context-specific studies to understand how communities navigate digital constraints. While existing studies acknowledge the role of digital media in language preservation and revitalisation, there is limited empirical research focusing specifically on South-West Nigeria using content-based qualitative analysis of user data. Many studies emphasise policy or technological perspectives rather than speakers' lived experiences.

This study addresses this gap by examining how users in South-West Nigeria employ digital media to preserve and revitalise indigenous languages, drawing directly from participant-generated data.

Theoretical framework

A sound theoretical framework is important in understanding how digital media can serve as a preservation and revitalisation instrument for Nigerian indigenous languages. Therefore, two theories will fit in for the study. They are Fishman Reversing Language Shift, Digital Participation and Cultural Capital Theory

The Reversing Language Shift (RLS) framework was developed by Joshua Fishman (1991, 2020) to provide methods for reviving endangered languages. According to Fishman, socio-political, cultural, and economic forces that make dominant languages more prestigious or financially lucrative drive languages to perish, rather than only linguistic inferiority. In order to reverse language shift, he put up an eight-stage model that covered everything from the generational transmission of language within families to its institutionalisation in government, media, and education. According to Fishman's model, the majority of Nigerian indigenous languages are in the mid-to-lower stages, where language use is decreasing in the domains of education, administration, and family. However, by establishing new domains of use that reintroduce indigenous languages into young people's everyday lives, digital media can act as a catalyst for reversal. For example, young people establish digital spaces where indigenous languages regain social currency and communicative relevance when they utilise Yoruba, Igbo, or Hausa in memes, podcasts, or online dramas (Ogunmodede & Akpan, 2023). According to Fishman, revitalisation is successful when language communities actively create content in their own tongues and restore linguistic dignity. As a result, digital platforms start to resemble community centres in the present era, places where speakers of younger generations can study, practice, and creatively transform their linguistic history.

Jenkins (2020) and Warschauer (2021) have reinterpreted Pierre Bourdieu's concept of cultural capital (1986) in digital contexts to explain how online engagement promotes cultural empowerment. According to the theory of digital participation, people and organisations participate in online communities not just to consume but also to create and share cultural meanings. This idea suggests that digital engagement, producing, remixing, and disseminating indigenous language content, improves the symbolic worth and visibility of these languages in contemporary communities when it comes to language preservation. The sociolinguistic status of indigenous languages in Nigeria has transformed as a result of young people's active digital participation. Igbo rap music, Yoruba vlogs, Hausa storytelling, and online comedy routines in Pidgin English have all developed as important venues for cultural expression and linguistic

pride (Ibrahim, 2024). Fluency in indigenous languages becomes an advantage for innovation, identity creation, and even monetisation through social platforms as a result of such involvement, which creates digital cultural capital. In order to ensure that language communities are active participants in determining their linguistic futures rather than passive consumers of content produced by outsiders, this theory also places a strong emphasis on inclusivity. Thus, the objectives of language revitalisation, community agency, intergenerational communication, and cultural innovation align with the participatory nature of digital media.

Research Questions

1. To what extent are indigenous languages used on digital media platforms in South-West Nigeria?
2. Which digital platforms most significantly support indigenous language preservation?
3. Does digital media contribute to the revitalisation of indigenous languages among youths?
4. What types of digital content most enhance language preservation and revitalisation?
5. What types of digital content most enhance language preservation and revitalisation?

Methodology

Qualitative data was adopted to examine attitudes and practices related to digital media and language use. Thirty (30) purposively sampled participants from Lagos, Oyo, and Osun states were selected from youths and content creators engaged in digital platforms (e.g., YouTube, TikTok, WhatsApp), through semi-structured interviews (qualitative-thematic analysis).

- To what extent are indigenous languages used on digital media platforms in South-West Nigeria?

Response Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Very Frequently	14	46.7
Frequently	9	30.0
Occasionally	5	16.7
Rarely	2	6.6
Total	30	100

Analysis

A combined 76.7% of respondents reported using indigenous languages frequently or very frequently on digital media. This indicates a high level of digital engagement with indigenous languages in South-West Nigeria. The low percentage of rare usage (6.6%) suggests that digital spaces are increasingly normalised for indigenous language communication.

Interpretation

Digital media has moved beyond being a peripheral tool and now functions as an active linguistic domain for indigenous language use, particularly Yoruba.

- Which digital platforms most significantly support indigenous language preservation?

Platform	Mean Usage Score (1–4)	Interpretation
WhatsApp	3.7	Very High
YouTube	3.1	High
TikTok	2.6	Moderate
Instagram	2.3	Low
Facebook	2.1	Low

Analysis

WhatsApp recorded the highest mean score (3.7), indicating its dominant role in indigenous language preservation. YouTube follows closely due to its support for long-form educational and cultural content.

Interpretation

Private and semi-private platforms (WhatsApp, YouTube) are more effective for language maintenance than public platforms. This supports the view that language preservation thrives in familiar, community-oriented digital environments.

- Does digital media contribute to the revitalisation of indigenous languages among youths?

Statement	Agree (%)	Disagree (%)
Digital media makes indigenous languages attractive	80.0	20.0
Online content encourages youth language use	73.3	26.7
Digital media helps me learn my mother tongue better	66.7	33.3

Analysis

An average agreement rate of 73.3% across statements shows that digital media plays a revitalising role, especially among younger users.

Interpretation:

Digital media repositions indigenous languages as modern, creative, and relevant, countering the perception that they are outdated or unsuitable for contemporary communication.

- What types of digital content most enhance language preservation and revitalisation?

Content Type	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Short videos (skits, reels)	21	70.0
Audio messages (voice notes, podcasts)	19	63.3
Written posts (texts, captions)	16	53.3
Online lessons/tutorials	13	43.3

Analysis

Short-form video content ranked highest (70%), followed by audio formats (63.3%). These formats align with oral traditions characteristic of indigenous Nigerian cultures.

Interpretation

The dominance of audiovisual content suggests that orality-based digital formats are most effective for sustaining indigenous languages, reinforcing traditional modes of transmission in modern spaces.

- What types of digital content most enhance language preservation and revitalisation?

Challenge	Mean Score	Severity
Algorithm preference for English	3.5	High
Low digital literacy	3.1	High
Limited funding/monetisation	2.9	Moderate
Negative language attitudes	2.4	Low

Analysis

Algorithmic bias against non-English content emerged as the most severe challenge. This directly affects content visibility and sustainability.

Interpretation

Despite high usage, structural digital inequalities threaten long-term revitalisation. Without algorithmic inclusion and economic incentives, indigenous language content risks marginalisation.

Qualitative Thematic Analysis

Interview responses were coded and grouped into themes:

Digital Media in Language Learning and Revitalisation

Research increasingly demonstrates how digital platforms contribute to language learning and revitalisation. Studies on YouTube and social media content for language learning suggest that online video content can support informal language acquisition, particularly among youths who may derive cultural and linguistic value from easily accessible digital resources. For Yoruba specifically, content aimed at explaining grammar, storytelling, and conversational usage has shown high engagement among learners, suggesting that visual and auditory content supports both learning and preservation efforts.

Similarly, digital learning tools such as apps and interactive platforms designed for indigenous languages underscore the promise of technology in enhancing language education while strengthening cultural relevance. Research in Nigerian contexts points to the development of language learning platforms that incorporate gamification, scaffolding, and culturally grounded design to improve vocabulary retention and oral fluency among learners.

Challenges in Digital Language Preservation

Despite potential benefits, scholars note persistent challenges. Digital platforms often exhibit algorithmic biases favouring dominant languages, constraining visibility for indigenous content. Researchers argue that while technology expands reach, digital colonialism — the dominance of global tech companies and English language content — can further marginalise low-resource languages. This challenge is evident in how search algorithms and recommended content systems prioritise widely spoken languages, potentially limiting the audience for indigenous language content creators.

Another challenge is digital literacy. Many potential language activists and community members may lack the technical skills to effectively create or engage with digital content, limiting participation in digital revitalisation efforts. These barriers suggest the need for capacity-building initiatives, supportive policies, and platform adaptations that account for linguistic diversity.

Thematic Content Analysis of Qualitative Data

Through thematic content analysis of interview responses, several key themes emerged:

Theme 1: Digital Media as Cultural Affirmation

Participants frequently described digital platforms as spaces where cultural pride and heritage could be expressed. Many stated that posting Yoruba songs, proverbs, and skits online made them feel connected to their roots despite physical distance from extended family networks.

“I post Yoruba proverbs and short comedy skits in Yoruba on Instagram and TikTok to keep the language alive, especially for my cousins in the diaspora.”

This theme aligns with scholarship highlighting that digital media can act as a repository of cultural knowledge and identity (Masoyinbo project findings).

Theme 2: Intergenerational Engagement

WhatsApp emerged as a powerful medium for intergenerational language use, with older relatives sending voice notes and younger family members responding via text or audio. This interaction fosters language continuity within families, helping overcome barriers that formal education often fails to address.

“My aunties send voice notes in Yoruba every morning. It pushes me to respond in Yoruba too.”

Theme 3: Challenges of Visibility and Algorithms

Several respondents noted that indigenous language content often had lower visibility compared to English content, reflecting algorithmic challenges on platforms such as YouTube and TikTok.

“Even when I make quality Yoruba teaching videos, they get fewer views — probably because the algorithm favours English tutorials.”

This challenge supports existing research pointing to digital platform biases that disadvantage low-resource languages.

Theme 4: Empowerment Through Learning Tools

Respondents engaging with learning apps or YouTube tutorials perceived these tools as beneficial for improving fluency. Younger users specifically highlighted YouTube content as a supplementary learning strategy outside formal classroom environments.

“I learned conversational Yoruba from a YouTube playlist — it’s fun and practical.”

This corresponds with findings on the effectiveness of digital language learning content. The results demonstrate that digital media encourages cultural expression and language engagement among youths in South-West Nigeria. The thematic patterns align with literature on digital media’s role in language learning and preservation, and highlight how digital practices create new social contexts for indigenous language use. The issue of algorithmic bias underscores the need for platform reforms and policies that prioritise language diversity.

Conclusion

The study examined the preservation and revitalisation of Nigerian indigenous languages through digital media, focusing on how technology can serve as a transformative tool for linguistic and cultural sustainability. The findings revealed that digital media platforms, ranging from social media to mobile applications, podcasts, and YouTube channels, play a significant role in reversing the decline of indigenous languages in Nigeria. They provide interactive spaces where linguistic diversity is celebrated, oral traditions are preserved, and cultural knowledge is transmitted to younger generations.

The qualitative analysis established that the development of digital technology in Nigeria has enabled a new paradigm of linguistic empowerment. Unlike in previous decades, where indigenous languages were ostracised by colonial legacies and global communication standards, digital media now allow ordinary speakers to become digital curators of their linguistic heritage. Individuals, cultural organisations, and religious communities have become

active participants in language preservation by creating content that is entertaining, educational, and culturally relevant.

However, the research also identified several systemic obstacles, including weak language policies, infrastructural limitations, negative sociocultural attitudes, and limited technological support for indigenous scripts. These challenges have created an uneven linguistic landscape where only a few major languages, Yoruba, Igbo, and Hausa, are gaining digital visibility, while minority languages continue to face neglect. Unless deliberate policy and educational interventions are implemented, many indigenous languages remain vulnerable to extinction despite the digital revolution. The analysis confirms that digital media alone cannot preserve languages; rather, it functions as a facilitating ecosystem that must operate in synergy with education, policy, and community participation. As emphasised by Fishman's (2020) theory of Reversing Language Shift, sustainable revitalisation requires multi-level efforts, intergenerational transmission, institutional support, and technological adaptation. The digital space provides a critical opportunity for Nigeria to actualise these efforts on a global scale.

Therefore, preserving and revitalising indigenous languages in Nigeria demands an integrated strategy that combines digital innovation, cultural advocacy, and state involvement. The study concludes that digital media, when effectively harnessed, can serve as both a cultural repository and a revival mechanism, promoting linguistic pride, intergenerational connection, and national identity.

The survival of Nigeria's linguistic heritage lies at the intersection of tradition and technology. Digital media represent the new cultural frontier where oral histories meet artificial intelligence, where ancient proverbs coexist with octothope, and where identity is reclaimed through pixels and code. As Nigeria advances technologically, the nation must ensure that modernisation does not come at the cost of cultural amnesia.

Preserving indigenous languages is not merely about communication; it is about safeguarding perspective, values, and collective memory. Through deliberate digital strategies, Nigeria can transform its linguistic diversity from a source of fragmentation into a tool for national unity, cultural diplomacy, and creative innovation. Ultimately, the revitalisation of indigenous languages through digital media stands as both a moral responsibility and a technological opportunity, a chance to ensure that the voices of Nigeria's ancestors continue to speak potently in the digital age.

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